which is nothing but the charge of an electron.

9.3 ATOM MODELS

Introduction

Around 400 B.C, Greek philosophers Leucippus and Democretus proposed the concept of atom, 'Every object on continued subdivision ultimately yields atoms'. Later, many physicists and chemists tried to understand the nature with the idea of atoms. Many theories were proposed to explain the properties (physical and chemical) of bulk materials on the basis of atomic model.

For instance, J. J. Thomson proposed a theoretical atom model which is based on static distribution of electric charges. Since this model fails to explain the stability of atom, one of his students E. Rutherford proposed the first dynamic model of an atom. Rutherford gave atom model which is based on results of an experiment done by his students (Geiger and Marsden). But this model also failed to explain the stability of the atom.

Later, Niels Bohr who is also a student of Rutherford proposed an atomic model for hydrogen atom which is more successful than other two models. Niels Bohr atom model could explain the stability of the atom and also the origin of line spectrum. There are other atom models, such as Sommerfeld's atom model and atom model from wave mechanics (quantum mechanics). But we will restrict ourselves only to very simple (mathematically simple) atom model in this section.

9.3.1 J. J. Thomson's Model (Water melon model)

In this model, the atoms are visualized as homogeneous spheres which contain uniform distribution of positively charged particles (Figure 9.8 (a)). The negatively charged particles known as electrons are embedded in it like seeds in water melon as shown in Figure 9.8 (b).

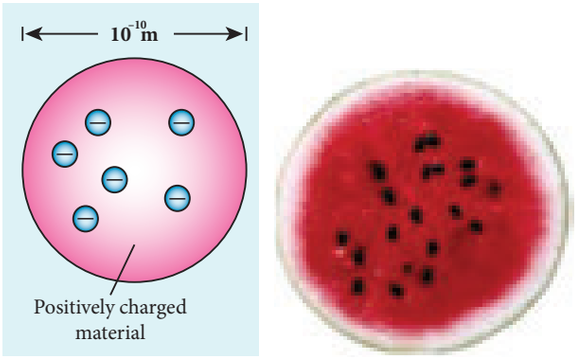


Figure 9.8 (a) Atom (b) Water melon

The atoms are electrically neutral, this implies that the total positive charge in an atom is equal to the total negative charge. According to this model, all the charges are assumed to be at rest. But from classical electrodynamics, no stable equilibrium points exist in electrostatic configuration (this is known as Earnshaw's theorem) and hence such an atom cannot be stable. Further, it fails to explain the origin of spectral lines observed in the spectrum of hydrogen atom and other atoms.

9.3.2 Rutherford's model

In 1911, Geiger and Marsden did a remarkable experiment based on the advice of their teacher Rutherford, which is known as scattering of alpha particles by gold foil.

The experimental arrangement is shown in Figure 9.9. A source of alpha particles (radioactive material, example polonium) is

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